



Say Earth Orbit First: A Letter to NASA

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

In the following open letter, written after NASA announced the crew of the Artemis III mission on June 9, 2026, a planetarium educator who hosts school field trips asks the agency to change how the flight is described to young audiences.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 To the National Aeronautics and Space Administration: I write from a low seat. I run the dome theater at a city planetarium, where my equipment amounts to a star projector, a microphone, and a carpet that has outlasted four directors; you, for your part, fly people off the planet. On June 9 you announced the four astronauts of Artemis III: commander Randy Bresnik, pilot Luca Parmitano, and mission specialists Frank Rubio and Andre Douglas. I have been saying their names out loud in the empty dome all week, practicing.

2 You will expect a letter like this one to want something, because letters like this one always want something: a poster, or a school visit, or a signed photograph for the lobby case. I am not asking for any of that. I am writing because of a girl in the second row on Tuesday, a few hours after your announcement, maybe nine years old, who held her hand up through the entire show and then asked me whether the four people on the screen would walk on the Moon. I told her the truth, and the truth took three sentences longer than she wanted. [Anecdote] Artemis III is not the landing.

3 Let me grant you something first, freely: wonder is your trade, you have been good at it for longer than I have been alive, and the crew you chose needs no varnish from me or from anyone [Concession]. You named a commander who has flown twice and commanded the International Space Station during Expedition 53; you named a pilot, Luca Parmitano, the station's first Italian commander and the first European Space Agency astronaut assigned to an Artemis mission; you named Frank Rubio, a board-certified physician and flight surgeon who left on a Soyuz in September 2022 and did not come home for 371 days, the longest single spaceflight any American has flown; and you named Andre Douglas, a backup for Artemis II who has never been to space. [Anaphora] Children gasp at the 371. Nobody has to tell them to.

4 And yet the flight plan, stated plainly, is this: Artemis III is targeted to launch in 2027 and will test rendezvous and docking, in Earth orbit, with test articles, practice versions, of the Blue Origin and SpaceX lunar landers; the first crewed landing at the Moon's South Pole is planned for Artemis IV, as early as 2028. If you trusted the plain record when you picked these four, if a doctor who was gone for 371 days and a pilot on loan from another continent's space agency were inspiring enough without any dressing, then the itinerary deserves the same confidence: lead with Earth orbit. [Cumulative and periodic sentences] Put it in the first sentence, not the fine print. The girl in the second row can hold two true things at once. She proved it before her bus left.

5 My fall calendar starts filling in late September, school groups mostly, four buses on a good Friday. Before the first of them arrives, publish one description of this mission that a nine-year-old could read to the end of its second sentence and still know where the spacecraft is going, and where it is not yet going.

You hold the larger instrument here; I only hold the microphone. Whatever you write, I will read it aloud under the dome, in the dark, to children with their hands already up. **That part is mine.** [Telegraphic sentence]

Devices, and why they are here:

Anecdote (paragraph 2): “I am writing because of a girl in the second row on Tuesday, a few hours after your announcement, maybe nine years old, who held her hand up through the entire show and then asked me whether the four people on the screen would walk on the Moon. I told her the truth, and the truth took three sentences longer than she wanted.”

The girl with her hand up gives the request a human stake; the writer's standing to ask anything of NASA comes from the child he has to answer, not from any expertise of his own.

Concession (paragraph 3): “wonder is your trade, you have been good at it for longer than I have been alive, and the crew you chose needs no varnish from me or from anyone”

Granting NASA's skill and good faith before making the ask lets the pressure read as loyalty rather than attack, and removes the agency's easiest reason to dismiss the letter.

Anaphora (paragraph 3): “You named a commander who has flown twice and commanded the International Space Station during Expedition 53; you named a pilot, Luca Parmitano, the station's first Italian commander and the first European Space Agency astronaut assigned to an Artemis mission; you named Frank Rubio, a board-certified physician and flight surgeon who left on a Soyuz in September 2022 and did not come home for 371 days, the longest single spaceflight any American has flown; and you named Andre Douglas, a backup for Artemis II who has never been to space.”

The repeated “you named” opening each clause stacks the crew's credentials one on top of the next, building the case that the plain record inspires on its own, without embellishment.

Cumulative and periodic sentences (paragraph 4): “If you trusted the plain record when you picked these four, if a doctor who was gone for 371 days and a pilot on loan from another continent's space agency were inspiring enough without any dressing, then the itinerary deserves the same confidence: lead with Earth orbit.”

The stacked “if” clauses withhold the main demand until the end, performing deference while making the request land as the conclusion the whole letter has earned.

Telegraphic sentence (paragraph 5): “That part is mine.”

After the letter's long deferential sentences, the clipped final line quietly claims the writer's small share of the work and hands the larger share back to NASA.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer catalogues the crew's flights, records, and firsts primarily to
 - A) emphasize the physical dangers the astronauts will face during the 2027 flight
 - B) concede that the writer lacks the expertise to evaluate the crew's qualifications
 - C) establish that the mission's plain facts can move an audience without embellishment
 - D) question whether NASA has selected a crew experienced enough for a lunar landing

2. In the first and final paragraphs, the writer's references to his own equipment ("a star projector, a microphone," "I only hold the microphone") serve primarily to

- A) lower the speaker's standing so the request rests on the addressee's power rather than the writer's authority
- B) suggest that planetariums lack the resources to keep pace with modern spaceflight
- C) illustrate the technical difficulty of presenting astronomy to school-age children
- D) contrast the writer's honesty with the agency's deceptive publicity practices

Multiple choice answer key:

1. **Answer C.** The catalogue follows the writer's grant that the crew "needs no varnish" and feeds the paragraph's closing claim that children gasp at the bare number, so its function is to prove the plain record persuades on its own. The option doubting the crew's experience inverts the writer's open admiration; the option about physical danger imports a concern the passage never raises; and the option about the writer's lack of expertise describes the letter's opening self-lowering posture, a true observation that does not answer what this catalogue accomplishes.

2. **Answer A.** The letter's deference depends on the writer claiming a small instrument against NASA's large one ("You hold the larger instrument here"), which frames the closing request as a matter for the agency's better nature rather than a demand from an equal. The resources reading imports a funding complaint the passage never states; the deception reading is more extreme than a letter that openly grants NASA's good faith; and the technical-difficulty reading takes the equipment literally instead of as a marker of the speaker's standing.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer asks NASA to "lead with Earth orbit" even though the plainer description is less exciting than a Moon landing. When does simplifying a story for an audience cross into misleading it, and who should get to decide where that line sits?

2. The letter is addressed to NASA, but it is written to be read by everyone. How does knowing the public is overhearing change what the writer can say, and how does it change what the agency can afford to do in response?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. Simplifying becomes misleading at the point where the short version creates a belief the full version would correct. The girl in the second row believed the four astronauts would walk on the Moon, and nothing in a crew announcement alone would have corrected her; that is why the writer wants Earth orbit in the first sentence, not the fine print. The audience itself is the best judge of the line, which is the force of the claim that a nine-year-old "can hold two true things at once": if the plain version still lands, the simplification was never necessary.

2. The public audience cuts both ways. It forces the writer into deference, because an open attack on NASA in front of everyone would read as grandstanding, so he grants the agency's good faith and asks rather than demands. But it also raises the cost of refusal for NASA: a private letter can be ignored quietly, while an overheard request turns silence into a visible choice. The form lets a person with only a microphone borrow the audience's weight without ever raising his voice.

Writing prompt (Q3 argument):

In an open letter to NASA, a planetarium educator claims that even a young audience "can hold two true things at once," and asks the agency to lead its public descriptions with the plain facts of a mission rather than its most exciting framing. Write an essay that argues your position on the extent to which institutions, such as agencies, schools, and companies, should favor plain accuracy over excitement when communicating with the public. In your response you should: respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible position; provide evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- "Artemis III is the Moon landing." It is not, and the passage turns on exactly this point: Artemis III, targeted for 2027, tests rendezvous and docking with lunar lander test articles in Earth orbit; the first crewed landing at the lunar South Pole is planned for Artemis IV, as early as 2028.
- "The letter is an attack on NASA." Students may read the request as criticism, but the writer concedes the agency's skill and good faith ("wonder is your trade") and applies pressure by holding NASA to its own demonstrated trust in plain facts; the deference is the engine, not a disguise.
- "The 'you named' series is just parallelism." Because the repeated phrase opens successive clauses, it is anaphora; if the repeated element sat mid-clause it would be parallelism. The distinction is the position of the repetition, not its presence.
- "The girl's question is a rhetorical question." It is a real question reported inside an anecdote; the writer poses no question for effect anywhere in the letter.

AP exam alignment:

MCQ 1 targets Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5), asking how the crew catalogue functions in the letter's line of reasoning. MCQ 2 targets Style (Skill Category 7), asking how the writer's self-presenting diction serves his persuasive strategy. The writing prompt is an AP Q3-style argument, generalizing the letter's contestable claim about plain accuracy versus excitement into a debatable proposition with no sources required. All labeled devices come from the controlled AP vocabulary: anecdote, concession, anaphora, cumulative and periodic sentences, and telegraphic sentence.